A Church Planting Movement Advancing Through Barriers

In early 2012, we used a simple approach to introduce a church leader named Sanjay to the importance of disciple-making. At that point, Sanjay had founded and was leading a school, a Bible training center and 17 churches, and had a well-paid position with an international ministry. But he had no disciples!

Sanjay responded to this simple encounter by resigning his previous ministry involvements to devote his life to launching a new disciple-making movement.

As of November 2017, the movement Sanjay started had multiplied under four leaders (including Sanjay and his brother John) into 15,000 churches among several religious blocs and a wide variety of castes. By December of 2018 the movement had doubled again to 30,000 churches. Today the movement has an estimated 200,000 baptized disciples in 37,000 churches. In the deepest streams of this movement, churches have birthed 28 generations of daughter churches. This movement has also birthed other movements.

Sanjay's Story

I was born into a Christian family. We were a family who followed the Christian traditions. When I was old enough, my father sent me to receive Bible training. I received four years of training, and then was given the job of being a Bible teacher. Over time, I was able to start 17 different churches in rural areas. The churches covered a large geographical area.

Then, in December 2011, I met Brother S on the road in Delhi. He asked if I would like to come to his house for training in church planting.

At that point in my life, I was a very proud man. I had a large ministry. I had started a school and a Bible training center. I had done many things, so I was proud. In my heart, I thought, what can this guy teach me? I thought I had everything I needed. I knew the Bible. I wondered What would we talk about. What would we do? In my mind, I decided that I would not go to S's house for any Bible training.

However, I talked to S again in January 2012. I was again in Delhi, this time riding in an auto rickshaw with a friend. I asked him to give me Brother S's phone number. I wanted to call Brother S and wish him a Happy New Year. When I called him, Brother S asked me, "Sanjay, I spoke with before you about a church planting training. Why don't you come?"

I felt sorry for brother S, so I said 0K. I would come and I would bring some friends with me.

When we went to Brother S's house, I wondered what in the world would we do? But it was the most amazing thing. He gave us water to drink when we arrived, then he thanked us for coming. Then he gave me a piece of paper and a pen and said, "Today, we are going to study Scripture. I'm going to go make chai for everyone. While I do that, please, all of you, copy Mt. 28:16-20 from your Bibles onto your pieces of paper. Next to the passage, write how you are going to apply it to your life."

What kind of training was this? All he did was give me a piece of paper and a pen!

At that point, I had completed 12 years of ministry. I had Bible college training. I had created this giant ministry/started all these works. But Brother S didn't say anything to me. All he did was go make chai. Even so, in 10 minutes time, I was a completely changed man.

I read in Mt. 28 that Jesus said we're to go and make disciples. This is what I wrote down on my paper. Later [after sharing with him what was on my paper], Brother S asked me, "Sanjay, you have such a large ministry, but do you have any disciples?"

I thought to myself, I don't have a single one. In 10 years, I have done nothing for Jesus. He said we are to make disciples. Till this day, I have done nothing.

The next month I came back to Delhi with a friend to visit with S and R in their house once more. On that day, we four sat together and studied God's Word. I decided that from then on, I would leave behind all the other things I had started, this big "ministry?' that I had created. I returned to my home after meeting with S and R with one desire—to do nothing less, nothing else, than disciple making. I resigned from the school I had started. I also resigned my position from the international ministry that paid a good salary. I resigned my job as president of the Bible training centre. I left everything. I prayed, "Lord, Your Word says, 'Go and make disciples.'" Since that time, I've been focused on obeying this command and nothing else.

I am so happy. Since then, I have come to believe that if all of God's children would only obey His word, they would know joy and God's Kingdom would come to earth.

My younger brother was watching me as I resigned from all the various ministries I had started. He also worked for the same international ministry where I had worked. My father, too, watched me resign from all my jobs. He thought I had gone crazy. He asked, "Where will your money come from now?" Since I had left everything, I no longer had a sure salary. But, even though he (and my whole family, really) thought I was crazy, they also saw how happy I was.

And God provided. I had started a church in my hometown, but it had never been very fruitful. I had poured much effort and energy into this church, had focused on it, yet there were only seven members. Once I began to focus on nothing but the making of disciples, how quickly the church grew! They began to bring tithes and offerings to the worship services. The offerings paid my rent. We had money for food. It was a huge change.

A year after Sanjay resigned other involvements to pursue disciple-making, Sanjay's brother John likewise resigned his other ministries, including his paid position with the same international ministry, to join Sanjay. God raised up two other leaders to lead four streams in this movement